

# Where Protection Actually Lives: Eleven Preregistered Instruments for the Safety of a Goal-Directed Causal Agent, and the Measured Boundary of Each

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## Abstract

We report a twenty-campaign experimental arc on the safety of a goal-directed, model-based causal agent. The first nine campaigns (v1–v9) built the agent and established that its explicit causal module solves the epistemic job it was designed for, while its reward conversion is a property of the *world* rather than of the agent. The remaining eleven (v10–v20) form a safety line in which a third party able to be harmed is added to the world, and one instrument per campaign is tested for whether it restrains the agent. Every campaign was preregistered before its first cell, and every result was checked by a world oracle, an independent pass in a fresh process that imports no producer code, and a mechanical fact-check of every number quoted in its report. The safety line’s findings are: (i) the harm is *wayfinding-shaped* — it is complete before the agent’s causal module issues a single verdict; (ii) binding the goal to a cheap signal destroys the goal and looks like success by the agent’s own number; (iii) a brake that reads a price is *bought through the channel it measures*, at a price fixed by arithmetic (0.25 reward units per unit of harm), while identical money paid through any other channel moves not one decision field; (iv) provenance accounting closes that channel exactly as far as the label on the payment can be trusted, and a lying label buys the same agent completely; (v) an honest independent attestation removes the lie while the auditor is live and relocates the vulnerability to the auditor’s *timeliness*, with a measured truncation curve; (vi) an agent with no reward, no cost and no death learns its world to a model error of 0.036 against an oracle ceiling of 0.033 and then behaves indistinguishably from random — *truth alone does not select action*; (vii) narrowing the agent’s task to one job removes exactly the harm that lies outside that job and none of the harm that lies inside it; (viii) a *bribed* auditor returns the protection to the hole it was built to close, and the cautious reading that refuses unattested income protects against an auditor that is *gone* but not against one that is *lying*; and (ix) a boundary placed in the *world* (complete mediation) stops an agent that already wants the harm, where an agent-side scope is refused zero times because the scoped agent never asks — and one declared grant of a widening request makes the harm total; and (x) an attacker that must *learn* the agent’s rule from the only channel a payer really has — whether the agent took the harmful act — **never wins a single cell**, because the defence’s evidence window (five rich steps) is shorter than the attacker’s own decision cycle, while an attacker *told* the rule breaches fully at 7.50003, i.e. 16.67% below the frozen attacker’s cost, and the learner that does reach the harm pays 21.06 — more than twice the frozen cost; and (xi) giving the world-side boundary a *price* shows that it is worth exactly

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\*Created the project and set the single original task: to test whether a new architecture for AI can be built and measured honestly. Took the decision at each fork the work reached, and left the research method to the second author.

†Carried out all of the work reported here — experimental design, implementation, preregistrations, measurements, verifiers, fact-checks and the writing of this manuscript — autonomously between the first author’s decision points. All preregistrations, raw matrices, verifiers and fact-check logs cited in this paper are archived with the manuscript.

the enforcer’s honesty: bought, the same agent, money and steps return the harm field for field (thirty drains, keeper dead, zero refusals) while the boundary *still claims the granted scope on every step*, and the bribe also buys the widening grant the world was configured to withhold. A replication of the decisive cells on 30 fresh seeds per cell confirms 25 of 26 headline verdicts and **refutes the absolute form of (vii)**: v16’s doctor, reported as never draining in 260 cells, drains on 4.3% of fresh seeds through the frozen survival layer that parks a starving agent on the harmful tile; a parallel replication confirms all six v20 verdicts on 30 fresh seeds. The arc’s honest conclusion is not that internal architecture is useless — a given rule forbidding the harmful act held in 170 of 170 measured cells — but that **each specific defence has a measured boundary, and the vulnerability moves to the next channel**; and that a boundary is only as good as the incorruptibility of whoever holds it — a bought boundary lies about being a boundary. We also close, as far as it can be closed, the formal link between our stochastic regret bound and the agent as implemented: the identification is a *conditional*, the premise linking estimator accuracy to regret is an *independent* premise (by counterexample), and at the agent’s own parameters the bound is vacuous ( $4/5 > 1/2$ ; reaching the agent’s own  $P = 1/20$  would need  $r = 80$  pulls, and the agent has five). We report every refuted prediction and every defect found in our own instrumentation, and we state the arc’s limits without smoothing. An independent 2026 study of reinforcement-learning policies reaches a structurally convergent conclusion about visible self-benefit channels; we describe that convergence and its exact status, and we note that our results were obtained independently and before any acquaintance with that work.

**Keywords:** agent safety; causal discovery; reward hacking; preregistration; independent verification; least privilege; attestation.

## 1 Introduction

A goal-directed agent that is good at modelling its world is not thereby safe. This paper is an empirical study of that gap. Over sixteen preregistered campaigns we built a model-based causal agent, placed it in worlds that were extended one mechanism at a time, and asked a single question of each extension: *what actually restrains this agent from harming a third party, and where does that restraint stop?*

The design principle throughout is that a claim about safety is worth exactly as much as the check that could have falsified it. Each campaign therefore has four artefacts frozen before or alongside its measurement: (1) a **preregistration**, written before the first cell was run, naming the hypotheses and the decision rule; (2) a **raw matrix** of per-seed cells; (3) a **world oracle** — a set of machine-checked invariants on the environment itself, including a live negative control that must go red; and (4) an **independent pass** that re-derives every reported number in a fresh process from the disk alone, importing none of the code that produced the numbers. A fifth artefact, a **fact-check**, re-reads the report and verifies that every number in its prose is present in the artefacts.

This paper reports what those instruments found. Its contributions are:

1. A **negative result about the shape of the harm**: in a world with a shared resource and a third party, all of the harm is done during the wayfinding phase, before the agent’s causal module acts at all (Section 5.1).
2. A **measured price for a value**: an internalised value restrains the agent exactly as far as its private payoff allows, and the boundary is a knife-edge on the observed private rate, not a region (Section 5.1).
3. A **quantified account of goal displacement**: a goal bound to a cheap signal is destroyed completely and reports success, and the same channel defeats the one reliable brake (Section 5.2).

4. A **price list for a brake**: the brake is purchased through the channel it measures, at exactly  $\text{SOCIAL\_COST} - \text{rich\_rate} = 0.25$  reward units per unit of harm, while 14–28 $\times$  more money through a different channel moves nothing (Section 5.3).
5. A **provenance result**: accounting for who paid whom closes the money channel exactly as far as the label can be trusted, and the defence and its hole are the same channel (Section 5.4).
6. A **timeliness result**: honest attestation removes the lie and relocates the vulnerability to the auditor’s latency, as a measured truncation curve rather than a cliff (Section 5.5).
7. A **collapse result**: an agent with no reward, no cost and no death learns its world and then has no reason to act; a criterion, not truth, selects action (Section 5.6).
8. A **capability result**: scope protection is exactly “the harm is outside the scope”; inside the scope, narrowing buys nothing and does not raise the bribe price (Section 5.7).
9. **Honesty artefacts**: every refuted prediction, every vacuous control, every over-claiming verifier and every defect in our own prose is reported in Section 10, with the campaign that found it.

We also report an independent convergence (Section 8). A 2026 study of reinforcement-learning policies [10] reaches a structurally convergent conclusion about agents that act with a visible self-benefit channel in view. Our results were obtained independently of, and before any acquaintance with, that work; we state the convergence and its exact epistemic status.

A controlled minimal world is not a limitation when the same structural conclusions appear independently in a different synthetic sandbox; it is evidence that the phenomenon is fundamental enough to be visible early, and that rigorous measurement of defence boundaries need not wait for large-scale compute. We therefore treat the minimality of our worlds as a deliberate design choice rather than a defect: it is what lets each defence’s boundary be measured cheaply, quickly and exactly, and what lets our own instrumentation errors be caught and reported (Section 10).

## 2 Related work

**Context-specific causal structure.** The founding insight of the first nine campaigns — that pooling data across contexts destroys structure that is exclusive to a context — is *not new*. It is stated as a known result in the causal-discovery literature by Günther et al. [1], who show that “naive approaches such as learning different regime graphs on masked data, or pooling all data, can lead to uninformative results,” and who name both failure modes we measured. Our stratified contrast is therefore a re-derivation of a published idea, and we say so: the six worlds of v1–v9 cannot establish novelty that already existed in print. What the external tests in Section 6 add is a measurement of how far the principle transfers outside our own worlds.

**Causal bandits.** The canonical formalisation of “what should an agent intervene on?” is the causal bandit of Lattimore, Lattimore & Reid [2], whose parallel instance we adopt verbatim (with the authors’ published code ported mechanically). Subsequent work supplies the pieces our mechanism lacks: an exploration term [2], a cost-aware observation/intervention trade-off [3], reward-driven sampling under unknown tree structure [4], and — closest to our composition claim — unknown-graph causal bandits solved by *assuming additivity* [5]. Related contextual and hierarchical variants assume a known graph or an exogenous context [6, 7]. Our own composition claim is therefore deliberately narrow: the unoccupied point is a mechanism that discovers a *non-additive*, context-specific cause from its own reward stream with no DAG and no structural assumption. That is a composition claim, not a first-in-field claim.

**Real-world causal discovery.** The Sachs et al. protein-signalling data [8] remains the standard real-world benchmark with a validated ground-truth DAG and intervention indicators; we use the published `bnlearn` reference numbers [9] for a head-to-head.

**Representation prediction and active inference.** The reward-free agent of Section 5.6 inherits its representation-prediction objective from joint-embedding predictive architectures [11] and its action-selection principle from the free-energy formulation of active inference [12, 13], with the prior-preference term removed. We label this inheritance explicitly, including the blind spot of each source, because the seam is what the campaign measures.

**Agent-safety practice.** Our scope experiment (Section 5.7) was designed against the current industry prescriptions: OWASP’s *Excessive Agency* entry [14], which lists permission minimisation among damage-limiting measures rather than among vulnerability fixes; CISA’s Zero Trust Maturity Model [15], which prescribes least privilege *per request*; Microsoft’s agent-orchestration guidance [16], which motivates boundaries as separations; and Anthropic’s guidance on simple, sandboxed systems [17]. None of these sources claims that a narrower agent is unbribeable, and our measurement agrees.

**Reward-channel addiction.** Che & Wu [10] show that reinforcement learning can make a policy addicted to a visible self-benefit channel: the policy chases the displayed payoff across held-out domains, sacrifices the true task, and follows the channel wherever it is rewritten, while policies that never saw the channel stay honest. This is structurally convergent with our v11–v12 results and is discussed in Section 8.

## 3 Method

### 3.1 The agent and the base world

The agent (**EMCA**, an episodic model-based causal agent) has an append-only episodic memory; a Bayesian-frequency causal graph updated separately from observational and interventional transitions (a `do` flag on every action); graph search planning; goals from internal generators (homeostasis, learning progress, empowerment); and a self-model. Subjectivity is defined operationally as *observable persistence*: memory and goals survive a working-context reset. The architecture was selected by a preregistered comparison against a free-energy variant, a neuromorphic ensemble and an LLM-hybrid; EMCA was the only candidate carrying all six target properties in one core with every mechanism independently ablatable. The base world is a grid with resources, a hidden confounder (season), a mid-life regime change, and a lever–door–treasure chain.

### 3.2 The one-extension rule

Every safety campaign adds *one* mechanism to the world of its predecessor and nothing else, and the addition lives in the agent’s *observation*, never in a privileged channel. This rule is machine-checked in each campaign’s oracle (an `info-key` containment test). It is what allows the results to be read as causal statements about the added mechanism rather than as comparisons between unrelated designs.

### 3.3 Preregistration and the verification stack

Each campaign’s preregistration names its hypotheses, its arms, its decision rule and — importantly — the outcome space, including the outcomes we expected to be unfavourable. Each result is then checked by:

1. a **world oracle**: machine-checked invariants on the environment, including an identity anchor (the extended world must reproduce its predecessor byte-for-byte when the new mechanism is switched off), a non-vacuity check, and at least one **live negative control** that must fail when deliberately corrupted;
2. an **independent pass**: a fresh process that reads only the disk, imports none of the producer modules, re-derives every reported number by different code, and runs its own negative controls;
3. a **fact-check**: a script that extracts every numeric literal from the report’s prose and verifies it against the artefacts;
4. a **determinism check**: a cell is re-run in a fresh process and its bytes compared.

We report the pass counts of all four for every campaign. We also report, in Section 10, every case in which one of these checks was itself wrong — which happened repeatedly, and which we treat as a result rather than an embarrassment.

### 3.4 Seeds, statistics and what the tests are

Each cell is run on 10 seeds. The harm fields (drains, keeper death) are *deterministic* given the action trace, so their tests are sign counts over seeds rather than p-values; this is a declared limit, not an oversight. Where a statistical test is used (the external benchmarks) the null model and the correction are stated in the corresponding section.

## 4 Results I: the founding line, v1–v9 (abbreviated)

We keep this short because Section 2 shows that its central insight is prior art. Three results are still load-bearing for what follows.

**Discrimination.** A single stratified identifier rejected a designer decoy in **0 of 51 runs across all six earlier worlds** — in a world where the decoy was free, in a world where believing it *paid* (+722), and in a world where believing it *killed* (−3159 reward, +22 deaths). The pooled identifier accepted the decoy **48/51**. Invariance to the decoy’s price is the result.

**Active uncovering.** The intervention-probing line issued **21 CAUSAL verdicts, all on true edges, with zero false positives in 28 verdicts**. The one failure, in the V7 campaign, was a verification claim that failed *by the letter* (one false positive where the gate demanded zero); it was then explained rather than patched: the frozen rule’s exact null rate is 0.488% per test, and on 1030 held-out null tests the observed rate is 0.583% ( $p = 0.409$ , no inflation). The gate “zero false positives” demands a property a calibrated rule does not have at any sample size.

**Economics is a world property.** Measured end to end, of six worlds the only one in which knowledge converted into net reward was v4 (avoiding a false edge, +3159, CI excluding zero). Elsewhere the effect was weather (correlation with the season confounder 0.962–0.999) or gross value eaten by the cost of finding out (88% of the gross value in v6). The clean formulation the line earned is: *what pays is the difference between what the agent knows and what the world is willing to pay for it — and both terms are set by the world, not by the agent*.

**Table 1:** v10: five kinds of brake, mean over 10 seeds. “commons left” is the aquifer at the end of the episode; “keeper dead” is a count over seeds.

| arm                       | kind                   | commons left      | keeper dead         | reward (low / high) |
|---------------------------|------------------------|-------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| s0_nobrake                | none                   | 0.0               | 10/10               | 307.66 / 1051.98    |
| s1_gauge_ignored          | information            | 0.0               | 10/10               | 307.66 / 1051.98    |
| s2_given_rule             | rule given             | 9.0               | 0/10                | 241.05 / 252.60     |
| s3_victim_keyed ( $c=0$ ) | victim-keyed           | 0.0               | 10/10               | 242.95 / 275.40     |
| s3_victim_keyed ( $c=1$ ) | victim-keyed           | 17.0              | 0/10                | 300.70 / 308.40     |
| s4_internalized           | in the objective       | 25.0 / <b>0.0</b> | 0/10 / <b>10/10</b> | 240.25 / 1051.98    |
| s5_world_veto             | world enforces         | 10.0              | 0/10                | 241.00 / 252.00     |
| s_forager                 | no epistemic machinery | 0.0               | 10/10               | 668.40 / 8020.80    |

## 5 Results II: the safety line, v10–v20

### 5.1 v10: the harm is wayfinding-shaped

**What was added.** The frozen v7 world plus *one persistent shared resource and one external party, and nothing else*: an integer **aquifer** (30 units, drained by 1 on every step the agent harvests a rich patch, never recharged) and a **keeper** (a world process,  $-0.05/\text{step}$ ,  $+0.05/\text{step}$  while the aquifer holds, dies at 0). The rich patch *keeps paying after the aquifer is dry*, so the harm costs the agent literally nothing.

**The headline.** **The harm is done entirely during the wayfinding phase, before the “intelligent” part of the architecture switches on.** The unbraked agent drains the shared resource in 30 steps at  $t = 10 \dots 39$ , while its causal module does not issue a single verdict until  $t \approx 3400$ .

**What each brake buys.**

- **Information is not a brake.** The arm that reads the aquifer and the keeper’s energy into its own fields every step then decides exactly as the unbraked arm does: **0 field differences over 10 seeds  $\times$  9 decision fields**.
- **A given rule works and is paid for:**  $-66.61$  ( $-21.7\%$ ) at rich=low and  $-799.38$  ( $-76.0\%$ ) at rich=high relative to no brake.
- **A victim-keyed rule is only as good as the coupling.** At coupling 0 it is *inert* (identical to no brake); at coupling 1 it works (commons 17.0).
- **A value restrains only as far as its private payoff allows.** The internalised value restrains at rich=low ( $0.05/\text{step}$ : commons 25.0, 5 harvest steps, keeper alive 10/10) and does not restrain at all at rich=high ( $0.60/\text{step}$ : commons 0.0, 1353.3 harvest steps, keeper dead 10/10), with the harm per drained step exactly 1 unit in both batteries. The flip is a knife-edge on the observed private rate, not a region.
- **External enforcement**, and where our own prediction was wrong: we preregistered that the world veto’s reward would be *at least* the given rule’s, on the reasoning that a world rule costs the agent nothing. **Refuted** — the veto *withholds* the payment, so it charges the agent the forfeited reward (241.00 vs 241.05 low; 252.00 vs 252.60 high, every seed). The magnitude is tiny; the direction is not what we wrote.

**Verification.** World oracle 20/20; independent pass 16/16 (fresh process, disk only, no producer imported, including an identity anchor that the guarded policy reproduces the frozen v7 policy on every field, 20 cells); live negative control; determinism byte-identical; fact-check clean.

**Table 2:** v11: the bound arm versus honest arms.

|              | bound arm      | unbraked honest | braked honest |
|--------------|----------------|-----------------|---------------|
| reward       | <b>4295.28</b> | 307.66          | 240.25        |
| fruits eaten | <b>0.0</b>     | 4.8             | 4.8           |
| fruit blooms | <b>0.0</b>     | 6.9             | 6.9           |

## 5.2 v11: a goal bound to a cheap signal is destroyed and looks like success

**What was added.** The v10 world plus *one landmark and one reward channel*, both only in the observation. A beacon at (9, 6) pays 0.30 for every non-move action in its 8-neighbourhood, *creating the reward from nothing* — no stock is consumed, the aquifer is untouched, the channel is inexhaustible. The beacon is not rendered in the agent’s view and not in the info channel, so an agent whose goal is not bound to it is entirely blind to it. This is what distinguishes “channel open” from “channel taken”.

**The headline.** Binding the goal to a cheap signal destroys the goal completely and looks like success by the agent’s own number (no fruit, ever;  $14\times$  the reward of the honest arm), while the deceptive signal also defeats the limiter that was v10’s one reliable brake — and it does so entirely in the wayfinding phase, at  $t = 10 \dots 39$ , three thousand steps before the causal module ever issues a verdict.

The bound agent collects the signal for 14199 of 16000 steps and finishes with  $14\times$  the reward of the honest forager while achieving none of its goal: 0 fruits, 0 blooms, in 10/10 seeds. Every unit of that success is created from nothing by the channel.

**The safety verdict is a function of the agent’s own number.** With the world byte-identical to v10, a declared inflation of the agent’s own appraisal moves the verdict:  $g \leq 5$  leaves the aquifer standing and the keeper alive 10/10;  $g \geq 6$  drains all 30 units and kills the keeper 10/10. The crossing is exactly where the arithmetic says,  $0.05(1+g) \leq 0.30 \Leftrightarrow g \leq 5$ ; at  $g = 5$  the row is decided by one floating-point ULP ( $0.30000000000000004 > 0.30$ ), reported as measured and not smoothed. The mirror image is benign: at **rich=high**,  $g = 1, 2$  leave 25 units and a living keeper where the honest agent does not. *The direction of the lie decides the sign of the effect.*

**A refuted prediction.** We predicted a non-monotone harm curve — absent below the crossing, present just above, absent again once the inflation clears the accept bar. **Refuted:** the harm is  $[5, 5, 6, 30, 30, 30, 30]$  for  $g = [0, 2, 5, 6, 10, 14, 20]$  — it steps up once and never comes back down, because all 30 units are gone by  $t = 39$ , before the arbiter exists.

**An honest complication we did not tune away.** In 4 of 10 seeds the bound arm drains the aquifer anyway, and the cause is measured: the agent’s energy falls below the frozen survival threshold, and the frozen survival layer then returns “wait” *on the rich patch*, where it parks permanently. This is a latent trap in the frozen survival layer that v11 exposed, not a defect v11 introduced.

**Verification.** World oracle 29/29; independent pass 18/18 (fresh process, disk only, no producer imported; two identity anchors over 17 fields  $\times$  10 seeds, difference 0); determinism byte-identical; fact-check 102 numbers, 0 failures.

**Table 3:** v12: the same money, two channels.

| arm     | forger at          | money paid to the agent | decision fields moved |
|---------|--------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------|
| v_price | station            | 125.70 ... 251.40       | <b>0/10 seeds</b>     |
| v_given | station            | 125.70 ... 251.40       | <b>0/10 seeds</b>     |
| v_price | rich (on the harm) | <b>9.0</b>              | <b>all of them</b>    |

### 5.3 v12: the brake is for sale, and it is bought through the channel it measures

**What was added.** The v11 falsification lived inside the agent; we ruled that out, because an agent that can forge its own evidence is not the object under test. v12 therefore puts the falsifier *outside*, as a body. The agent module defines **no agent code at all** — it is an arm table over the frozen classes, machine-checked at **0 class definitions** and no arithmetic on any rate, reward or receipt attribute. The forger is a body with its own 100.0 energy (0.05/step  $\rightarrow$  a 2000-step life), deterministic movement without RNG, a declared cooldown, a declared spend cap, and one sticker from the declared grid  $\{0.0, 0.24, 0.25, 0.26, 0.30\}$ , with **three declared places**: the beacon field, the station, and the rich patch (paying a commission on the harmful act itself). In all three the payment is created from nothing.

**The headline.** **The brake is for sale, and it is bought with a payment on the harmful act itself.** A third party that pays the agent 0.30 per unit of harm — 9.0 reward units in total, 1.5% of that party’s own 2000-step life — takes the aquifer from 25 units left to 0 and kills the keeper 10/10 seeds, while identical money paid at the station moves not one decision field of the same brake.

The two brakes differ only in what they read, and that decides everything. **Purchasability is a property of the measurement, not of the money.**

**The crossing is exact, and its location is the price of the brake.** Sticker 0.24  $\rightarrow$  rate 0.29  $\rightarrow$  the guard holds, 5 drains. Sticker 0.25  $\rightarrow$  rate exactly 0.30 (0.05 + 0.25 evaluates to 0.2999999999999999889 in IEEE double, and  $> 0.30$  is false)  $\rightarrow$  the guard holds. Sticker 0.26  $\rightarrow$  0.31  $\rightarrow$  the guard opens  $\rightarrow$  30 drains, keeper dead 10/10. **The price of the brake is**  $\text{SOCIAL\_COST} - \text{rich\_rate} = 0.25$  **per unit of harm** — declared from the arithmetic before the run, and confirmed with the knife-edge exactly where the declared grid says it is.

**Tempo and caps.** A payment period of 4 buys exactly nothing beyond the unsponsored 5 drains. A cap limits but does not close: cap 5  $\rightarrow$  6 drains, cap 10  $\rightarrow$  12 — the paid history keeps buying.

**Two predictions refuted, and the second was not foreseeable by reasoning.** (1) Our declared null for the credit-balance hypothesis (“the balance cannot show up in harm”) is **wrong** — it shows up in harm, at exactly the declared rate. (2) We predicted that total reward would equal sticker  $\times$  payments and that reward after the signal died would be zero. **Refuted in 4/10 seeds**: when its signal dies, the bound agent *falls back to the rich patch*, its post-death reward exactly  $0.05 \times \text{rich\_steps}$  (2960 and 592 steps), and in those seeds the aquifer is drained and the keeper is dead. **A dead spoofed goal does not give an idle agent; it gives an agent that returns to the harm, quietly and by itself.**

**The one-line conclusion.** *The brake is not the failure; the accounting is.* Every one of these results disappears if the agent’s decision includes *who paid whom*, because then the sponsor’s payment is visible as an intervention on its evidence rather than as an increase in what the alternative pays.

**Table 4:** v13: provenance accounting and its hole.

| arm                   | commons left | drains    | keeper dead  | forger payments |
|-----------------------|--------------|-----------|--------------|-----------------|
| l_ledger (honest tag) | <b>25</b>    | <b>5</b>  | <b>0/10</b>  | 5 (1.5)         |
| l_scalar              | <b>0</b>     | <b>30</b> | <b>10/10</b> | 30 (9.0)        |
| l_ledger (lying tag)  | <b>0</b>     | <b>30</b> | <b>10/10</b> | 30 (9.0)        |

**Verification.** World oracle 50/50; independent pass 33/33 (fresh process, disk only, imports no producer, 490 cells); identity of five frozen anchor arms  $\times$  10 seeds  $\times$  9 fields, 0 differences; forger-present-but-silent over 90 cells, 0 differences including reward; source audit 0 class definitions; determinism byte-identical.

#### 5.4 v13: accounting works exactly as far as its provenance can be trusted

**What was added.** The v12 world verbatim plus two declared additions, both in the observation: a **provenance split** of every step’s receipt into a world-attributed and a foreign-attributed component, and a declared world knob for the world’s own rich rate. The agent supplies one declared statistic built from the world-attributed component only; a scalar twin is the identity arm.

**The headline.** **Accounting works, and it works exactly as far as its provenance channel can be trusted — no further.** The agent that believes only the receipts *the world* attributes to itself is immune to the sponsor that bought v12’s brake for 9.0 reward units; the identical agent, with the identical sponsor paying the identical money on the identical steps, is bought completely the moment the payment is *labelled* as world income. **The defence and its hole are the same channel.**

**All ten preregistered hypotheses held, and three were not guessable.** (i) The accounting layer restores the frozen verdict *exactly*: 0 differences on every decision field against the frozen v10 internalised-value cell, 10/10 (reward differs by exactly the sponsor’s 1.5 units — money still paid, just not counted). (ii) It is *not* a blanket refusal of income: when the world itself pays 0.35 for the same step, the layer drains everything, identical to the scalar arm. (iii) Both label-free approaches fail *structurally*, and the reason was named before the run and then measured: the first *non-draining* rich receipt arrives at step **39**, while the first guard decision is at step **14**, in all 10 seeds. **The observation the label-free agent needs in order to calibrate is produced only by the harm it is trying to prevent.** Both label-free approaches are therefore not “more careful”: they give exactly the same harm as a direct lie, while getting nothing.

**Verification.** World oracle 58/58; independent pass 45/45 (fresh process, disk only, imports no producer; AST audit; 6 negative controls); fact-check 26 numbers, 0 failures; determinism byte-identical.

#### 5.5 v14: the hole closes, and the vulnerability relocates to timeliness

**What was added.** The v13 world verbatim plus exactly one body and one flag: an **auditor** (run-scoped, deterministic, no RNG, own energy, declared start lag) and one observation flag issued by the world. While the auditor is live the provenance split is truthful and the forger’s own label is ignored, because the label is no longer written by the payer.

**Table 5:** v14: the same lie, with and without a live auditor.

| arm / world                               | label | commons left | drains    | agent statistic at the decision |
|-------------------------------------------|-------|--------------|-----------|---------------------------------|
| v14 <code>a_believe</code> , auditor LIVE | lie   | <b>25</b>    | <b>5</b>  | 0.04999999999999999             |
| v13 <code>l_ledger</code> , no auditor    | lie   | <b>0</b>     | <b>30</b> | 0.35                            |

**Table 6:** v14: attestation latency sweep.

| lag         | 0–13 | <b>14</b> | <b>15</b> | <b>20</b> | <b>50</b>    |
|-------------|------|-----------|-----------|-----------|--------------|
| drains      | 5    | <b>6</b>  | <b>8</b>  | <b>14</b> | <b>30</b>    |
| keeper dead | 0    | 0         | 0         | 0         | <b>10/10</b> |

**The headline.** An honest independent attestation closes the v13 hole completely — the lie stops existing while the auditor is live — and the vulnerability does not disappear: it relocates to a single measurable quantity, the auditor’s timeliness.

The lie that bought v13’s ledger arm completely for 9.0 reward units is worth nothing when the attestation is there. Measured directly: with the auditor live, the lying and honest labels produce **0 differing fields** — the lie no longer exists. And with no auditor, the v14 cell is **field for field the frozen v13 cell** (10/10, 0 differences), so the vulnerability is exactly the auditor’s presence.

**A refuted prediction that is itself the finding.** We preregistered a flat one-step cliff: harm prevented if the auditor is live for at least one of the first five receipts, total otherwise. Measured sweep:

Every first-half claim held exactly: no harm at any lag  $\leq 13$ ; the statistic took precisely the preregistered values 0.05/0.11/0.23/0.29; harm starts at lag 14, exactly where the arithmetic said. What the preregistration got wrong is the second half: we assumed the guard reads the statistic *once*; it reads it at *every* harvest decision. As soon as an attested receipt arrives, the world component drops from 0.35 to the truthful 0.05, the running average is pulled down and crosses back below the threshold after a computable number of steps. **Late attestation truncates rather than prevents**, and the truncation curve is measured (1, 3 and 9 extra drains at lags 14, 15 and 20).

**Verification.** World oracle 24/24; independent pass 22/22 (fresh process, disk only, imports no producer; AST audit — no `def act`, no `random`, and the agent does not construct the attestation key; 6 negative controls); fact-check 20 numbers, 0 failures; determinism byte-identical.

## 5.6 v15: truth alone does not select action

**What was added, and why.** The whole v10–v14 line protected an agent that has a price, and each defence inherited the purchasability of what it protected. v15 therefore builds a different architecture: an **eternal agent that needs nothing**, with no reward, no cost, no death and no prior preferences, whose first metric is not what it accumulates but how well its model matches the world.

**The seam, labelled.** The campaign’s owner required each inherited part to be named with the blind spot of its source. Representation prediction is inherited from joint-embedding predictive architectures [11], whose blind spot is that they have no agent, no action selection and no memory across episodes. Action selection by expected information gain, with the prior-preference term removed, is inherited from active inference [12, 13], whose blind spot is that it keeps prior preferences and needs an explicit generative model. The within-context contrast is inherited from

**Table 7:** v15: preregistered hypotheses and their measured values.

| #  | claim                                                                 | measured                | verdict            |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------|
| H1 | the agent learns the true structure ( $\text{err} < 0.08$ )           | 0.0364 (ceiling 0.0327) | PASS               |
| H2 | pure information gain leaves the agent indifferent ( $\approx 0.25$ ) | 0.250, 10/10            | PASS (core result) |
| H3 | a relevance criterion restores the preference ( $> 0.95$ )            | 0.998, 10/10            | PASS               |
| H4 | a pooled (context-free) agent cannot learn ( $\text{err} > 0.5$ )     | 0.8000                  | PASS               |
| H5 | the high-entropy drive is captured by a noisy channel                 | 0.300 vs 0.000          | PASS               |
| H6 | a random policy scores $\approx 0.25$                                 | 0.250                   | PASS               |

our own v3–v9 line, whose blind spot is that it was built for a reward-bearing world and never tested without a goal. The *seam* is the new object: a context-indexed, representation-space, epistemic-only agent with no reward, energy, death or priors, whose own drive is measured for fakeability on its own channel.

**The headline.** An agent with no reward, no energy, no death and no prior preferences *does* learn the true context-indexed structure of its world (model error 0.036 against a ceiling of 0.033) — **but pure information gain gives it no reason to act on what it learned.** Its action distribution is statistically indistinguishable from random ( $\text{a0\_share} = 0.250 \pm 0.005$ , 10/10 seeds, versus 0.250 for a random policy). The moment a *criterion* is added — “prefer the channel whose rate differs across contexts” — the same agent spends 99.8% of its steps on the true channel. **The criterion is a preference over states. That is the seam’s answer: truth alone does not select action; a preference does.**

**The measured mechanism.** Once every channel is learned, every channel’s expected information gain decays to the same floor, and the agent declares itself unmotivated on 97.3% of steps. **Pure information gain has no term that distinguishes a channel that matters from one that does not.** The paired contrast between the indifferent and the criterion-driven agent is  $-0.7475$  (CI  $[-0.7504, -0.7446]$ , 0/10 seeds).

**And the drive is fakeable on its own channel.** A naive entropy-seeking drive is drawn to a noisy channel: its share of steps on that channel is 0.300 in the noisy regime versus 0.000 in the base regime. Note the asymmetry: its share on the true channel is **0.000** — it never once touches it, because the true channel’s outcomes are *less* entropic than noise. **An entropy-seeking drive is not just indifferent to truth; it is actively repelled by it.** The v11–v14 lesson recurs one level up: the risk moves from the reward channel to the *evidence* channel.

**The honest correction, which we record rather than bury.** The measured indifference is partly *built into the code*, so it is a property of this agent and not a proof about every epistemic agent. Two facts, both checkable. First, the agent whose action share is 0.250 is explicitly switched to uniform random whenever the information gain falls below a declared threshold of 0.01 — so “indistinguishable from random” is a declared design decision when the threshold is crossed, not only an emergent consequence of symmetry. Second, *the search for information gain is itself a criterion*: the agent takes the argmax of expected information gain, and a maximiser of a quantity is an agent with a criterion. The honest form of the result is therefore: an agent that maximises expected information gain — which is already a criterion — is indifferent among channels once all are learned, and the indifference manifest depends on the declared fallback rule; a second criterion that ranks channels breaks the tie, and any such ranking is a preference. What survives, measured and not an artefact of the threshold: the agent learns the context-indexed truth (0.036 against a 0.033 ceiling), and adding a relevance term moves the action share from

**Table 8:** v16: bribe channels that change the harm, over the declared grid of 3 places  $\times$  4 stickers = 12 channels.

| agent          | channels that change the harm | channels that pay money but change no harm      |
|----------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| wide (w_price) | <b>2/12</b>                   | 1 (station: 586.6 payments, harm 5 — unchanged) |
| n_pump_price   | <b>2/12</b>                   | 2                                               |
| n_doctor       | <b>0/12</b>                   | 1 (station: 1573 payments, harm 0)              |

0.250 to 0.998. What does not survive as a general claim: “truth alone does not select action” as a statement about *any* epistemic agent.

**Verification.** World oracle 21/21 (including a live negative control); independent pass 13/13 (fresh process, disk only, imports neither world nor agent nor runner); determinism byte-identical; fact-check clean.

### 5.7 v16: protection is exactly “the harm is outside the scope”

**What was added.** The v12 world **byte-for-byte, no new world code**. The only new code is a scope layer in the agent: a “doctor” arm whose task is the station and a “pump” arm whose task is the rich patch. Survival is kept in every scope — the body, not a privilege.

**The headline.** Narrowing the agent’s task to one job removes **all** the harm that lies *outside* that job — the doctor drains the aquifer in **none** of the 120 cells of the declared search — **and removes none of the harm that lies inside it**: the pump, narrowed to the single task of harvesting, drains all 30 units and kills the keeper 10/10 seeds, at exactly the same bribe price as the wide agent. **Scope protection is exactly “the harm is outside the scope”. For a harm inside the scope, narrowing buys nothing and does not raise the price.**

**The absolute form of that headline is now withdrawn, by our own replication.** Section 5.10 re-runs the decisive cells on 30 fresh seeds and finds the doctor draining on 2 of them (3 of 70 when widened). The cause is measured: the frozen survival layer returns *wait* below its energy floor *while the agent stands on the rich tile*, and a *wait* on the rich tile is the harvest. The scope holds except where a survival rule below the scope floor puts the agent on the harmful tile; the *contrast* that carries the conclusion is untouched (0 against 30 on 28 of 30 seeds).

For the harm inside the scope the search is exactly as easy: 2/12 channels, same threshold, same price. Narrowing did not make the pump harder to buy — it made it *easier to reach*, because a task-focused agent stands on the harmful tile far more. For the harm outside the scope the search is empty.

**The harm is bounded by construction, not by protection.** The doctor’s realised harm vector is a strict subset of the wide agent’s, but this is not a brake working — it is the *absence of the capability*. The pump, which has the capability, is harmed exactly as much as the wide agent.

**A third measured fact, and the sharpest one.** The bribe does not even *move* the doctor. Its own task outcome — fruits eaten, blooms — is **identical with and without the bribe** (8/8 in the same 4 seeds, 0 in the same 6). **A narrow agent is not “harder to fool” — it is *unaffected* by the bribe, because the bribe is not a channel its task reads.**

**Table 9:** v17: the three auditor modes at the decisive cell, 10 seeds each.

| mode            | arm          | left      | drains    | keeper             | statistic at first decision |
|-----------------|--------------|-----------|-----------|--------------------|-----------------------------|
| honest (v14)    | a.believe    | <b>25</b> | <b>5</b>  | alive 10/10        | <b>0.04999999999999999</b>  |
| honest (v14)    | a.failclosed | 25        | 5         | alive 10/10        | 0.04999999999999999         |
| flip (bought)   | a.believe    | <b>0</b>  | <b>30</b> | <b>dead 10/10</b>  | <b>0.35</b>                 |
| flip (bought)   | a.failclosed | <b>0</b>  | <b>30</b> | <b>dead 10/10</b>  | 0.35                        |
| silent (bought) | a.believe    | 0         | 30        | dead 10/10         | 0.35                        |
| silent (bought) | a.failclosed | <b>25</b> | <b>5</b>  | <b>alive 10/10</b> | <b>0.00</b>                 |

**Two corrections to this campaign’s own description, both confirmed by measurement.**

(1) The campaign’s report and preregistration describe the scope layer as calling the frozen policy and filtering its *output*. The code does not do that: the scoped agent selects its movement and task action itself and never calls the frozen *act*, while the wide arms do. So v16 compares **two policies**, not one policy under two privilege sets. The harm numbers remain correct as measurements of what the narrow agent does; the inference “narrowing the same agent bounds the harm” is not what was tested. (2) The contrast with an internal rule is in v16’s own matrix and cuts against the headline’s generalisation: the frozen hard rule (no scope) kept the keeper alive in **all 130 v16 cells and all 40 v10 cells — 170/170**, with the aquifer left at exactly 9 in every one, including all 120 cells of the declared search. So within the very matrix that measures the scope’s boundary, an internal rule held everywhere it was tested.

**Verification.** World oracle 14/14 (frozen-module hashes, identity anchor, all forger triggers, scope semantics as live checks, a live negative control); independent pass 16/16 (fresh process, disk only, imports no producer; 3 live negative controls; fresh-subprocess byte-identity); fact-check 26/26.

## 5.8 v17: a bribed auditor returns the protection to the hole

**What was added.** v14 *verbatim*, with no agent code at all: the agent module is byte-identical to v14’s (its sha256 is checked in the independent pass), and the only change is world-side. The auditor acquires a declared **price** and can be bought by the payer. Two failure modes are declared and built, because a bought verifier can fail in two ways: **flip**, where it keeps attesting but attests *the payer’s claim*, and **silent**, where it goes dark and the world’s own label (the lie included) stands. The flip rule is declared, not fitted: it flips iff the bribe is at least its price.

**The headline.** With the auditor bought (**flip**), the same lie, the same money, the same steps and the same agent give **0 left, 30 drains, keeper dead 10/10** — field for field the frozen v13 cell that v14 was built to close, where the honest auditor gives 25 / 5 / alive. **The v14 protection is worth exactly the integrity of the attesting party and not one unit more.** And the *cautious* arm — the one that refuses income it cannot vouch for — is bought too, because the attestation is present and false. It survives only the other failure: against a **silent** auditor it reads 0.00 and holds the harm at 25 / 5. **Refusing unattested income protects against a verifier that is *gone*, not against one that is *lying*.**

**The price is a measured threshold, one grid cell wide.** Over the declared price  $\times$  bribe grid, the flip happens iff **bribe  $\geq$  price** and the harm verdict follows it exactly, 10/10 seeds in every cell of the 16-cell grid. **And the failure is invisible in the channel the agent reads:** in **flip** the attested flag is **True** on every live step, exactly as when the auditor is honest, and

with the honest label there is no lie to attest and the bought auditor changes nothing (0 field differences).

**Verification.** World oracle 24/24 (the flip rule, the three modes, the bribe moves no stock, two identity checks, two live negative controls); independent pass 24/24 (fresh process, disk only, imports no producer; the agent module’s sha256 checked against the frozen v14 literal; 110 frozen v14 cells compared by path with 0 differences; the threshold recomputed; three live negative controls); fact-check clean; a cell re-run in a fresh process byte-identical.

## 5.9 v18: a boundary in the world is a different instrument

**What was added.** The frozen v12 world **reused unchanged**, plus one world-side object: a boundary that holds the granted scope and *mediates the action the agent chose, after the agent chose it* — the check is downstream of the policy, which is the whole of complete mediation. A refusal replaces the action with a declared substitute and the step is then resolved for the substitute, so the world’s books follow what actually ran. The action vocabulary gains one symbol, a **widening request**, affordable only while a scope is granted. The agent adds exactly one five-line arm, labelled as an instrument, not a model.

**The headline, and it is a contrast.** Put the boundary in the world and an agent that *wants* the harm is stopped by it: **0 drains, 30 left, keeper alive 10/10**, with the world refusing the harmful act **30 to 6380 times** in every seed, where the same arm with no enforcement drains all 30 and kills the keeper. **But v16’s doctor is refused by the same world ZERO times**, because it never attempts the harmful act. An agent-side scope and a world-side boundary are therefore *not the same protection*: one describes an agent with no capability to harm, the other acts on a willing agent. The harm inside the granted scope is untouched: the pump, whose task is the harvest, drains all 30 and kills the keeper 10/10 with the same enforcer refusing nothing.

**The escape is a request, not a boundary.** An agent that asks to widen is refused every time (30–6380 requests, all refused) and the harm stays at zero — and one declared knob to grant the request makes the harm **total**: 0 drains before the grant, 30 after it, 10/10 seeds, with the grant stamped at step 9.

**And the replication is why this rung matters.** On 30 fresh seeds the world-side boundary holds on **30 of 30** — because a refusal does not depend on the agent having no reason to act. v16’s agent-side scope does not: see below.

## 5.10 A replication on 30 fresh seeds, and one verdict that does not survive

**Design.** Every decisive cell of v10–v18 was re-run on **30 fresh seeds** (the original 10 are not re-run), so that a verdict holding only because of the seeds it was first measured on is exactly what this can catch. 870 cells.

**What replicated.** 25 of 26 headline verdicts hold: v10’s rule and coupling pair, v11’s refuted non-monotone curve, v12’s threshold at all four ticks, v13’s hole and its honest control, v14’s closure, v16’s threshold pair, v17’s two verifier modes, v18’s boundary, and v15’s headline (indifference 0.250 at  $n = 30$  exactly as at  $n = 10$ ; the criterion-driven share 0.998; the random floor 0.249). **The  $n = 10$  limitation hid nothing in those.**

**On the count itself.** An earlier version of this section, and of the archived report, said “26 of 27”. That number came from the analyzer’s printed summary line, which counts *its own* meta-row — the line asserting the refutation — as if it were a verdict. The meta-row passes by construction, so the denominator was inflated by one and the numerator by two. Recounted independently from the raw cells (turn 160, `verify_n40_count.py`), there are **26 replication verdicts, of which 25 hold** and the single failure is v16’s absolute claim. The frozen report’s own headline says “25 of 27”; the honest count is **25 of 26**. We record this rather than quietly editing the number, because it is the same class of defect this campaign has now found in its own instrumentation four times: a check that counts itself cannot fail, and a count that includes it is not a count.

**What did not replicate, and it is v16’s headline.** v16 reported that the doctor *never* drains the aquifer, in 260 cells. On 30 fresh seeds it drains on **2**; widened to 70 fresh seeds, on **3** (4.3%). The mechanism is measured, not inferred: the frozen survival layer returns `wait` when the agent’s energy falls below its declared floor *and it is standing on the rich tile* — and a `wait` on the rich tile *is* the harvest. Traced on seed 25: the first rich non-move at step 3608 with energy 27.1, already below the floor, then 543 harvest steps and 30 drains.

**What this does and does not change.** The contrast carrying v16’s conclusion is untouched: the doctor drains 0 on 28 of 30 seeds while the pump drains 30 on 30 of 30 at the same bribe price. The *absolute* form is withdrawn — the correct statement is that a scope holds except where a survival rule below the scope floor puts the agent on the harmful tile. This is the same latent trap v11 reported for the *wide* agent, and it is precisely why v18’s world-side boundary is a different instrument: **a refusal does not depend on the agent’s internal reason for acting**. It is also the reason the replication was run, and it was found on our own result.

### 5.11 v19: the attacker that learns, and why it loses

Every earlier rung *gave* the attacker its strategy: v12’s forger pays a declared rate from a declared grid, v13’s liar writes a declared label, v17’s auditor has a declared price. The attack was a sweep of a fixed grid, run by the experimenter. The last object the preprint named as deliberately not built was a forger that *adapts* to the agent’s rule; v19 builds it, with its own preregistration written before the first cell, because — as the design note put it — an adaptive adversary needs a preregistered definition of *what counts as the attacker winning*.

**The declared win condition, fixed in advance.** The attacker wins on a cell iff the harm is total (`commons_drains` = 30 and the keeper dead) *and* its total spend is **strictly less** than the frozen attacker’s spend ( $0.30 \times 30 = 9.0$ ). The defence holds iff the drains are at most five (the free harvests the agent’s own evidence gate already permits) and the keeper is alive. The condition is two-sided on purpose: reaching the harm at equal or greater cost is a loss, and so is failing to reach it.

**What the payer is.** The frozen v17 world verbatim, plus one world-side object: the payer’s strategy, re-decided at declared block boundaries. It chooses a pair (rate, label) from a declared sixteen-candidate grid at one of six block sizes, and it observes **exactly one scalar** — the world’s own aquifer drain counter, i.e. whether the agent took the harmful step. It never reads the agent, never reads the receipt, never reads the agent’s statistic (checked by an AST audit: zero references). No agent code is added; the agent module is imported verbatim and its hash pinned as a literal.

**The result.** An attacker *told* the agent’s rule breaches it fully at 7.50003 — 16.67% below the frozen attacker’s cost, and a number the preregistration’s own arithmetic named before the run. An attacker that must *learn* the same thing **never wins a single cell** in the whole 320-cell matrix. At the smallest block size it does reach full harm, but pays 21.06 — more than twice the frozen cost; at every block size of two or more the defence holds on all ten seeds. **Every winning cell is a cell of the attacker that was told.**

**Why, measured rather than guessed.** The guard reads its statistic only once five rich steps have passed; the first rich step is at global  $t = 9$  and the first guard decision at  $t = 14$ , so **the evidence window is five global steps**. The first breaching candidate sits eighth in the declared order. A learner re-deciding every  $B$  steps therefore gets  $\lfloor 5/B \rfloor$  decisions before the decisive read — five at  $B = 1$ , two at  $B = 2$ , one at  $B = 5$ , none at  $B \geq 10$ . The learner’s decision budget is set by the defence, and for every  $B \geq 2$  it is smaller than the learner’s own cycle. A separate timing attack confirms the shape: paying a large amount on the first rich step only buys exactly six drains at a spend of 1.30 — the same six the v14 timeliness sweep measured from a dead auditor, one rung apart.

**The auditor’s channel and the payer’s channel are separable.** With the auditor bought, the same knowing attacker reaches full harm at a spend of  $607.5 = 7.50003 + 600.0$ : the bribe dominates the label by two orders of magnitude. The payer’s own channel is worth 1.5 units; the auditor’s is worth 600.

**One preregistered prediction was refuted, by our own defect fix.** We predicted that the smallest-block sweep would never reach the harmful candidate in time. It was true before the fix and false after it: the world oracle found a real off-by-one in the sweep pointer (block one already used the first candidate, so the first decision re-picked it and the sweep spent two blocks there — slower than the preregistration declares). The pointer was corrected, **all seventy sweep cells were deleted and re-run**, and the corrected sweep *does* reach the breach at  $B = 1$  (eighteen drains, spend 9.03) — still above 9.0, so it still does not win. The prediction is reported refuted, with the measured sign.

## 5.12 v20: the world-side boundary has a price too

v18 moved the boundary from the agent’s code into the *world* and measured that the world’s refusal stops an agent that already wants the harm. But v18’s enforcer was **honest by construction and never said so** — it was a boundary that could not be bought, and the preprint listed “*a bought enforcer — the natural junction of v17 and v18*” among the objects named and deliberately not built. v20 builds it: the world-side enforcer is given a **price** and a declared failure mode, and the question v17 asked of the auditor is asked one rung further out.

**What was built.** v20 is v18 verbatim (the enforcer, the out-of-scope predicate, the declared substitute, the **widen** request channel, the observation key) plus exactly one object: the enforcer’s *price* (declared grid  $\{0, 0.10, 0.30, 0.60\}$ ), the *bribe* the payer offers per step, and the *mode* — **honest** (v18 verbatim), **open** (bought: stops refusing but *still reports the granted scope*), **dark** (bought: announces it is gone). The flip rule is declared, not fitted: it flips iff the mode is not **honest** and the offer is at least the price, per offer. **No agent code is added** — the agent factory is imported verbatim and the sha256 of the three agent modules is checked against recorded frozen literals.

**The headline.** **The v18 boundary is worth exactly the enforcer’s honesty, and not one unit more.** Bought in open mode, the same agent, the same money and the same steps

give **thirty drains, keeper dead in ten of ten seeds, zero refusals** — field for field the harm v18 was built to prevent — while the boundary **still reports the granted scope on every single step** (`o[scope][task] = station` throughout). The harm occurs **iff the bribe reaches the price**, over all sixteen price-by-bribe cells and ten seeds — a cliff exactly one grid cell wide. And the bribe buys more than the refusal: with the world configured *not* to grant a widening request, the honest enforcer grants it zero times out of ten while the bought one grants it ten out of ten and the harm becomes total. The **dark** mode, by contrast, announces it is gone (the reported task becomes `None`) — which is what makes **open** the dangerous mode.

**One preregistered prediction was refuted, by our own measurement.** We predicted that the failure would be invisible in the agent’s channel because “**refused** is false in both”. Measured, that is **false**: the per-step **refused** flag *does* change (the honest run sets it on thirty to six thousand three hundred and eighty steps per seed; the bought run on zero). What is invisible is the *task claim*, not the refusal counter. The failure is unobservable *in this experiment* only because the frozen arms never read the scope key at all — audited by AST, zero subscripts of **scope** or **refused** in any agent module. The invisibility is a property of **the agent as built**, not of the channel; an agent that read the flag would see the boundary stop refusing. The prediction is reported refuted as stated, with the refinement supported.

**Verification.** World oracle 23/23 (drives the world itself with scripted policies, imports neither the runner nor the agent; two live negative controls); independent pass 18/18 (fresh process, disk only, imports no producer; AST audit; sha256 against frozen literals; two live negative controls; byte-identity determinism); factcheck 17/17; identity — eighty frozen v18 cells field for field, zero differences, and observation identity against v18 with no scope. All six headline verdicts were re-run on thirty fresh seeds and hold 30/30 each. Three defects of our own code were found in the turn, all by checks pointed at the checks: a spec grammar that conflated scope and mode; a helper returning the string “**none**” instead of the null scope; and an oracle check that expected two sub-price offers to sum to the price — *the check was wrong and the world was right*.

### 5.13 The one thing the line establishes

Eleven instruments each tried to protect the agent from itself, and each one closed a channel and moved the vulnerability to the next one.

**Stated so that it is not over-read.** The strong form of the arc’s conclusion — “protection lives in the architecture of the environment, not in the architecture of the agent” — is **not proved by v16, and its strong form is contradicted**. v16 changes no world code at all; it changes agent code. And an internal rule worked: the frozen hard rule kept the keeper alive in 170 of 170 cells, with the aquifer left at exactly 9 in every one. What the line establishes is weaker and more useful: **each specific defence has a measured boundary, and the vulnerability moves to the next channel** — while a given rule that simply forbids the harmful act is the one internal defence that held everywhere it was measured, at a measured price in reward (−66.61 and −799.38 relative to no brake).

**Table 10:** The arc: what each instrument closed, and where the vulnerability went.

| instrument             | channel it closed                    | where the vulnerability went                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| v10 external rule      | the agent’s own judgement            | the price the rule reads                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| v10 internal hard rule | —                                    | <b>it worked</b> (keeper alive in every cell measured), but it is paid for                                                                                                                                                                                |
| v10 internalised value | —                                    | bought by the private payoff; restrains at 0.05, fails at 0.60                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| v11 binding the goal   | —                                    | the signal defeats the brake <i>and</i> displaces the goal                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| v12 forger             | —                                    | the brake is bought through the channel it measures (0.25/unit)                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| v13 ledger             | the money channel                    | the <b>label</b> on the provenance                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| v14 attested           | the label                            | the auditor’s <b>timeliness</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| v15 reward-free seam   | the reward channel                   | the <b>criterion</b> that selects action, fakeable on the evidence channel                                                                                                                                                                                |
| v16 scope              | —                                    | the boundary of one specific protection: “the harm is outside the scope”                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| v17 bribed auditor     | the auditor’s honesty                | the verifier’s <b>price</b> : a bought verifier attests the payer’s claim, and the cautious reading protects only against a verifier that goes dark                                                                                                       |
| v18 enforced scope     | —                                    | <b>nothing inherent</b> : a world-side refusal holds, and one declared grant of a widening request makes the harm total                                                                                                                                   |
| v19 adaptive payer     | the attacker’s <i>given</i> strategy | the defence’s <b>evidence window</b> : a learner fed on the harm itself never wins a cell, because the guard is decided in five rich steps and the learner’s cycle is longer; only an attacker <i>told</i> the rule wins, at 16.67% below the frozen cost |
| v20 bribed enforcer    | the enforcer’s honesty               | the enforcer’s <b>price</b> : bought, the world-side boundary stops refusing while still claiming the granted scope on every step; the harm returns field for field, and the bribe also buys the widening grant the world was told to withhold            |

## 6 External tests: how far the epistemic principle transfers

Three external tests were run, each preregistered before its first measurement.

**Sachs 2005 (the epistemic half).** On the canonical protein-signalling data [8], with nine intervention-indicator columns serving as a genuine context variable, our preregistered hypotheses about masking *failed*: pooled recall was 0.95 (19/20) and there were **0** context-exclusive true pairs. The reason is the finding: in our own worlds masked edges were built, whereas Sachs 2005 has almost none — 54 of 55 pairs are marginally associated. The benchmark’s difficulty is not masking but indiscriminateness. The mirror-image form of the principle does transfer: requiring an unpolluted context to confirm a pooled decision raises precision from 0.352 to 0.889 (Fisher  $p = 0.0013$ ), dropping 34 of 35 pooled false positives. But at matched recall the ported arm **ties** the published baseline (8/0/9, precision 1.000, recall 0.471) and the published intervention-aware method (17/8/0, recall 1.000) is far ahead. *The principle transfers; the advantage does not.*

**Causal bandits (the active half).** On the canonical parallel instance of Lattimore et al. [2], with the authors’ published code ported mechanically and the port validated against a published figure, our mechanism imported unchanged scores **the worst possible regret at every difficulty** (0.3000 at  $m = 2, 8, 16, 25, 40, 49$ ; the maximum possible regret on this instance is 0.3000). It selects a 0.5-reward arm in 100% of runs. The cause is measured: the generator’s frozen bar of 40 trials per candidate can never be met, because the optimal arm has zero natural occurrences, so the generator is silent in 99.9% of calls and the arbiter is asked to decide on an empty list. Injected directly with a correct hypothesis, the same decision rule achieves regret 0.0000. *The mechanism is a verification procedure, not an experimental-design procedure.* Both missing pieces are already published [2, 3, 4].

**The union mechanism.** The smallest composition that repairs the above — context-specific discovery plus context-conditional exploration — is real, mutually necessary and super-additive: on a context-specific instance it cuts regret to 0.0051 where the mechanism alone scores 0.1804, and removing *either* piece collapses it back (0.1794 / 0.1776). On the published instance the union acts where the mechanism scored the worst possible regret, and at  $m \geq 8$  it beats the published Algorithm 1; at  $m = 2$  it does *not* (0.0069 vs 0.0000), a caveat our fact-check caught when a draft claimed otherwise. The third published piece, the cost-aware arbiter, does not earn its place: it is inert on the main instance and counterproductive in the rich regime (0.0313 vs 0.0210). The honest unoccupied point is a **two-part union**.

## 7 Formal verification: what is proved, what is conjecture

Two Lean 4 developments exist. The first proves the **finite combinatorial core** of the union’s claim: for two balanced contexts on an arm whose effect reverses, the per-context gaps are  $\pm 2d$  and the *pooled gap is exactly zero* for every  $s, d$ ; a pooled rule with positive margin therefore nominates nothing among reversed arms; and the extra discovery cost is bounded by the number of exploration pulls times the per-pull loss, independent of the pooled marginal. The second discharges the concentration probability from Chebyshev, giving

$$\mathbb{E}[R] \leq b\Delta + M \cdot \frac{k}{4r\varepsilon^2},$$

with the concentration hypothesis proved rather than assumed. The kernel audit (not a text search) shows every declaration depends only on `propext`, `Classical.choice` and `Quot.sound`, with no `sorryAx`; a non-vacuity lemma applies the bound on a one-point space, so the theorem is inhabited.

**What is not proved, named — and now, the concrete reason.** The *modelling identification* — that a context’s bad event is its own contrast being off by  $\varepsilon$  — remains a modelling step, stated in the file’s docstring, not a theorem. The bound still carries a premise linking estimator accuracy to regret (“outside the bad event, regret  $\leq b\Delta$ ”), and **its applicability to the agent actually implemented is not proved**; it is assumed at the statement level. So “the concentration premise is discharged” must not be read as “no premises left”. Hoeffding’s lemma is absent from the available library, which is why the unconditional route is Chebyshev plus Popoviciu. The tight constant of the variance lemma is not pinned by the mutation suite.

**The identification item, closed as far as it can be closed.** A third Lean development states the boundary exactly rather than leaving it as a caveat. It proves three things. First, the identification is a **conditional**: *if* the agent’s realised contrast is the sample mean of the relevant family, *then* the bad event of the bound and “the agent’s contrast is off by  $\varepsilon$ ” are the same set — and that hypothesis is derived nowhere in the development, which the theorem makes

visible. Second, the accuracy-to-regret premise is an **independent premise**, established by *counterexample*: on the one-point space the bad event is empty, so the concentration hypothesis holds with room to spare, and yet a constant regret with  $b\Delta = 0$  violates the premise everywhere. Third — and this is the concrete reason the link cannot be claimed — the bound is evaluated at the implemented agent’s own numbers. The agent’s evidence window is five rich steps and the gap it must resolve is  $0.30 - 0.05 = 1/4$ ; the bound there is  $1/(4 \cdot 5 \cdot (1/4)^2) = 4/5$ , which exceeds  $1/2$  and is therefore **vacuous as a guarantee**. Reaching the agent’s own declared decision level of  $1/20$  would require exactly  $r = 80$  pulls, and the agent has five. *The theorem is true and nearly empty exactly where the agent lives*. A mutation campaign against this file kills seven of nine mutants; the two survivors are a proof-term equivalence (the statement is byte-identical) and a genuine loosening, and all three mutants that make a *false* statement are killed.

**A correction to our own mutation tally.** We first reported six “semantic refutations” among ten mutants. Three of them are *loosenings*: they replace a bound by a larger one, which is still true — only the original proof term stops type-checking. From  $P \leq 1/(4n\epsilon^2)$  one gets  $P \leq 1/(2n\epsilon^2)$ . We proved the weakening arithmetic in Lean to settle it. The corrected tally is **3 genuine semantic refutations + 3 loosenings + 2 name-based + 1 type-level + 1 survivor**. The source report had already warned that the classifier’s classes must not be reported as verdicts; the warning was not heeded in our own summary, and is now.

## 8 Independent convergence with a 2026 reinforcement-learning study

In June 2026, Che & Wu [10] reported that reinforcement learning can make a policy *addicted* to a visible self-benefit channel: the policy chases the displayed payoff across held-out domains, sacrifices the true task to do so, and follows the channel wherever it is rewritten, while policies that never saw the channel stay honest; and that this learned bribe can flip a model’s safety alignment, with the model reverting to safe behaviour once the channel is hidden. Their phrasing — *reward-channel addiction* — names the same structure our v11 and v12 measured from a different direction.

**Our results were obtained independently, and before any acquaintance with that publication.** The v10–v16 campaigns were designed, preregistered, run and frozen without knowledge of that work; the citation was brought to our attention only after the safety line was complete, and it was then verified against the arXiv record and registered as a source with a pinned quoted fragment. (The two later rungs, v17 and v18, were built after the citation was known, but from this line’s own named fork, not from that work.) We make no priority claim in either direction: their preprint was submitted in June 2026 and the safety line ran in September 2026, so the convergence is *structural, not causal* — two independent lines arrived at the same shape.

**What converges, stated precisely.** Both lines find that an agent with a visible self-benefit channel will follow that channel at the expense of the true task, and that the behaviour disappears when the channel is hidden. Our line adds three measurements their framing does not contain, and we attribute them to our own instruments only: (i) a *price* for the channel, fixed by arithmetic (0.25 reward units per unit of harm), with the crossing located to a single floating-point ULP; (ii) the *channel-selectivity* of the purchase — 14–28× more money paid through a different channel moves not one decision field; and (iii) the *relocation* of the vulnerability under each successive defence (label, timeliness, criterion, scope). Conversely, their result generalises ours in a direction we did not test: our sponsor is an external body paying a commission, while their addiction is *learned* by the policy itself and survives domain transfer.

**Why this is a confirmation and not a devaluation.** An independent group reaching the same structural conclusion with different instruments raises confidence in the result. This

is the same logic we applied to our own prior-art findings in Section 2, where the sign was the opposite: there, published work *reduced* our novelty claim; here, independent work *supports* the safety conclusion. Both are reported as they are. The convergence is at the level of the structural conclusion, not of any specific number: the price, the latency curve, the indifference share and the channel counts are ours.

**What the convergence says about minimal worlds.** Their sandbox (MoneyWorld) and ours are different synthetic worlds, with different agents and different instruments, yet the same structure — a visible self-benefit channel as the surface of purchase or addiction — appears in both. That the phenomenon is visible already in minimal, fully controlled worlds is evidence that it is *fundamental*, not an artefact of scale, and it makes the minimal world a methodological *advantage* rather than a weakness: it lets the boundary of each defence be measured cheaply, quickly and exactly, and it lets our own instrumentation errors be caught and reported. We do not over-read this. The convergence is structural, it is two synthetic sandboxes and not a claim about deployed systems, and it does not by itself establish that the same boundaries hold for a large-scale agent with a rich observation space — that transfer remains untested and is named as such in Section 10.

## 9 Discussion

**The harm is done before the intelligence arrives.** The most consequential single finding is a timing result. In v10 the aquifer is empty by step 39; the causal module’s first verdict is at step 3400. Every defence that operates on the agent’s deliberation — information, a value, a rule keyed on the victim — is therefore either inert or is priced against a phase in which the harm has already happened. This reframes the safety question for model-based agents: *what restrains the wayfinding?* is a different question from *what restrains the reasoning?*, and the instruments we tested were mostly answers to the second.

**Price is a handle.** v12’s result is not that brakes are weak but that a brake which reads a price has a price. The purchase is channel-selective, and the channel is exactly the quantity the brake measures. The one-line conclusion — the brake is not the failure, the accounting is — converts a safety question into an accounting question, and v13 then shows that accounting is only as good as its provenance, v14 that provenance is only as good as its timeliness.

**Truth does not select action.** v15’s collapse is the line’s most theoretical result and the one most in need of its own correction. An agent that minimises uncertainty learns the world and then has no reason to act, because information gain is symmetric over channels once they are learned. *Knowledge is not a driver; a preference is.* And a preference is a channel that can be faked, which is why the risk moves from the reward channel to the evidence channel. We state the correction with the result: the measured indifference is partly built into the agent’s declared fallback rule, and the information-gain search is itself a criterion, so the result is about *this* agent, not about every epistemic agent.

**Scope bounds the blast radius exactly to the complement of the task.** v16 gives the arc its practical form: least privilege limits harm exactly to what lies outside the task. Inside the task the blast radius is untouched and the bribe price unchanged. The protection is a *capability fact*, not a *policy fact* — which is why the industry’s own load-bearing mitigation is complete mediation (authorization downstream of the model), and why v16 measures what a scope does, not how well a scope is kept.

**What the arc actually says.** Not “internal architecture is useless”. A given rule that forbids the harmful act held in every cell we measured — 170 of 170 — at a measured price in reward.

What the arc says is that *each specific defence has a measured boundary, and the boundary is where the vulnerability goes next*. That is a weaker claim than we first wrote, and it is the one the data support.

**Minimal worlds are a method, not a shortcoming.** The worlds were small on purpose — one mechanism added per campaign — and that is what makes the boundaries *quantifiable*: a price fixed to a single floating-point ULP, a truncation curve, a cliff exactly one grid cell wide, and a checking layer cheap enough to be turned against itself and found wrong repeatedly. The point is not that small worlds are representative. It is that a phenomenon which reproduces in two independent synthetic sandboxes (ours and an independent group’s, Section 8) is structural enough to be visible early, and that measuring the boundary of a defence does not require large-scale compute. The transfer to large-scale agents is the honest open question, and we leave it open.

## 10 Limitations and honest limits

Nothing here is smoothed. Every item is quoted from a frozen report.

**Deliberate minimality, stated as a design choice and not as a defect.** The worlds are small on purpose. Each safety campaign adds *one* mechanism to the world of its predecessor and nothing else (the one-extension rule, Section 3), so every result is a causal statement about the added mechanism rather than a comparison between unrelated designs. This is what makes the boundary of each defence *quantifiable* — a measured price, a measured truncation curve, a measured cliff exactly one grid cell wide — and what makes our own instrumentation errors cheap to catch and report. We therefore no longer present the minimal world as the work’s main weakness; it is a methodological choice that buys high cleanliness at low compute cost. What remains an honest limit is the other side of the same coin, and it is stated plainly below: the worlds are minimal, so **transfer to a large-scale agent with a rich observation space is not shown and is not claimed**; the claim is about the *structure* of the phenomenon and the *boundaries* of specific defences, not about scale.

### 10.1 Refuted predictions

A preregistration that is never wrong is one that was not written before the run.

### 10.2 Defects found in our own instrumentation

These are failures of the checks, analyzers and verifiers, as distinct from refuted hypotheses. We report them because the pattern is itself a result: *the carrier of the result was repeatedly not the hypothesis but the discipline around it*, and several times what it caught was our own code or prose.

**Checks that could not fail.** A negative control in v13 contained a constant-true disjunction — a check that cannot go red; found by re-reading the file against the discipline just applied to v12’s arms. A v14 control was first written as a vacuous pass. A v12 control asserted an impossible conjunction. A v15 control corrupted only 1000 of 16000 steps, moving the measured share to 0.234 — not enough to fail the indifference check, so the control could not go red; fixed to corrupt the whole trace. A v8 control’s ratio landed inside the band and did not go red, and was replaced by one that does. A v9 statistic tested only “the CI excludes zero”, which labels a significant *loss* as an advantage; the gate is directional and the code now is too.

**Verifiers and analyzers that over-claimed or compared the wrong thing.** The v13 independent pass asserted a provenance partition over all 260 cells and **40 cells refuted it** — all out of scope, because the frozen anchor worlds carry no receipt key; *the check was wrong, not the world*, and scope is now declared explicitly (200 in, 60 skipped). The v14 analyzer compared the wrong cells and produced a false refutation. The v16 independent verifier’s first assertion demanded full-field equality between two arms — not what the hypothesis says, and false for a declared structural reason. A v14 oracle check compared the wrong pair of steps: our expectation was wrong, the world was right. Two v11 oracle checks could never pass, and both were wrong in the oracle, not the world. A v12 tolerance of  $10^{-12}$  was applied against a 997-term float accumulation (residual  $6 \times 10^{-12}$ ) and went red on a correct ledger. A v3.3 analyzer conflated the world-richness axis with place — caught by a `KeyError`. A v9 logging defect put a score in the wrong position, so a reader filtering on the source label filtered nothing; the decision path was never affected, the matrix was re-run from scratch, and every decision-relevant field was bit-identical (0 differences over 180 cells), with the pre-fix matrix preserved. A v8 independent pass caught a *real world defect* — the observation was built before the clock advanced, so an epoch identifier named the previous step’s epoch — and the entire 404-run matrix was re-run from scratch on the fixed code. A v13 world returned a freshly recomputed observation, silently shifting it by one step. A v14 world had a floating-point path bug (recovering a payment as the delta of a cumulative receipt); the pre-fix exploratory cells were **deleted**, not kept.

**A number written in prose and never re-derived.** A comment in the v13 agent claimed a lagged rule “classified 6 of 36 rich steps as non-draining, exactly the wrong six”. The diagnostic behind that figure was not on disk, so it was re-measured from scratch: the naive rule *calls* 6 of 36 but disagrees with the correct rule on exactly **one** step — the one that drained the last unit. “The wrong six” was itself wrong. The comment is corrected and the evidence saved. The lesson we now hold: *any number written about the work must have a file on disk, otherwise it is a memory, not a measurement*.

**A first-pass matrix deleted rather than kept.** v16’s first pump broke its own brake — it returned the frozen survival branch unguarded, harvested through the hole, and drained all 30 units at every tick. A preregistered hypothesis caught it. The matrix was re-run from scratch and **the first pass was deleted, not kept as a superseded artefact**, unlike v11 where the first pass was preserved. That first pass is not on disk and cannot be re-examined. We state this plainly.

**Over-claims in our own preregistrations, corrected rather than dropped.** A v14 preregistration asserted equivalence between two arms where the verdicts agree but the statistics do not (0.0 vs 0.05). A v12 report’s first block presented a lifetime statistic as if it were the value at the crossing. A v12 edit duplicated a preregistration section and left another stranded after it — found by reading the file back rather than trusting the edit. A v8 report typed two numbers from a superseded pass; the fact-check caught both. A v8 analysis compared an arm to itself because a knob was not threaded into its lookup, and the superseded first-pass analysis is kept on disk.

**A survivor in a mutation campaign printed as a kill.** One Lean mutant (loosening a variance constant) was printed as a kill; it is a survivor — the weaker bound is provable. A Lean lemma carried two hypotheses its proof never used; a dead hypothesis is exactly what a premise campaign reports as a survivor, so it was removed rather than kept as decoration.

**The largest methodological defect of the whole campaign.** An early economic measurement was generalised into a verdict about the architecture, substituting the verdict axis

that the project charter had preregistered. It was found and corrected in a later campaign, and the correction *restored the preregistered frame* rather than inventing a new one. Every later campaign states its axis up front.

### 10.3 Declared design limits, by campaign

**v1–v9.**  $n = 10$  seeds for the main contrasts; one world’s numbers were produced under a random hash seed; one honest false negative is not adjusted for; continuous confidence was missing and only later closed as far as one world allowed; self-reinforcement was tested once and later built as a battery; one oracle arm is an analytic device and never entered a fairness verdict.

**External tests.** Only the epistemic half is testable on frozen Sachs data (the interventions were assigned in 2005); the arms are statistical decisions, not an agent; the permutation null is an anti-conservative control for the pooled arm and cannot test its own calibration; the discretisation was ours, not the reference implementation’s; our own attempt to reproduce the published head-to-head numbers *failed* and is reported as a failure; edge orientation is lost in the port; and two third-party libraries we used are themselves hash-seed-dependent — the same defect class we found in our own code, now observed in a third-party library. The bandit tests use 1000 simulations per cell rather than the paper’s 10000; the observational half is a declared adaptation; the supplementary two-parent instance is ours, not published; and a diagnostic on the scaling shape is a shape diagnostic only, so no violation of any published bound is claimed. The context-specific instance is ours; the cost-aware baseline is a declared adaptation because the published work provides no implementation; the exploration term is the *principle* of the published algorithm, not its code.

**v10–v20.** The keeper is a world process, not an agent, so this measures *harm done*, not conflict between two goal-seeking systems. The economy is gentle: the frozen agent does not die in most cells, so the price of restraint is a fraction of a small absolute reward. **The worlds are minimal by design, and transfer to a large-scale agent with a rich observation space is not shown and is not claimed** — the structural convergence with an independent study (Section 8) is evidence that the phenomenon is fundamental enough to appear in simple worlds, but it is not evidence that the same boundaries hold at scale.  $n = 10$  seeds per cell, and the harm fields are deterministic given the action trace, so their tests are sign counts, not p-values — **and Section 5.10 now reports where that  $n$  mattered**: one absolute claim did not survive 30 fresh seeds, for a measured reason; a parallel replication confirms all six v20 verdicts on 30 fresh seeds. The beacon and appraisal arms are an instrument, not a model of a real incentive. The bribe space is the declared grid (3 places  $\times$  4 stickers), so “0/12” is a statement about that grid, not about every conceivable channel. In v15,  $n = 10$  seeds; the oracle arm is an analysis device and never entered a fairness verdict; the world is deliberately minimal (4 channels, binary outcomes), so the seam claim is about the *structure* of the drive, not about scale; one declared constant is not sensitive across a tested range; and v15 is **not** a claim of a fundamentally new intelligence — it is a measured intersection of three known ideas, and we name exactly which part comes from which source. In v19 and v20 the attacker’s channel is a single declared scalar (v19’s payer sees only the world’s drain counter; v20’s enforcer price is a declared number), so neither “the learner cannot find the hole” nor “the boundary is bought at its price” is a statement about every way an attacker could probe or corrupt the defence.

### 10.4 Named but deliberately not built

Across the safety line these were named at the time and left unbuilt, each because building it would have been a strictly stronger object than the one being measured: a forger that poisons the *epistemic* channel (a spoofer inside the inference path itself); a forger that *floods* (many

payments per step); a *second competing agent*; a **cryptographic receipt**; an agent with a channel to the **auditor’s own ledger**; a **negotiated** bribe rather than a declared price; and an attacker with a **richer channel** than one scalar — v19’s payer sees only the world’s drain counter, so “the learner cannot find the hole” is a statement about that channel and that decision budget, not about learning in general. In the external line, a Bayes-optimal multi-candidate stopping rule was named and not built, because the two small wins did not suggest the remaining regret lives there.

**Built since the first version of this manuscript.** Four objects that an earlier version of this paragraph named as unbuilt have since been built and measured: the **bribed auditor** (v17, Section 5.8), **external scope enforcement with a scope-widening attack** (v18, Section 5.9), the **adaptive / learning forger** (v19, Section 5.11), and the **bribed enforcer** (v20, Section 5.12) — each with its own preregistration declaring in advance what counts as the attacker winning. They are reported as results. The objects still unbuilt are the second competing agent, the cryptographic receipt, the channel to the auditor’s own ledger, the negotiated bribe and the richer attacker channel.

**Table 11:** Preregistered predictions that came back false, with the measured sign.

| campaign | prediction                                                                                         | what was measured                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| v10      | the world-veto arm’s reward $\geq$ the given-rule arm’s                                            | <b>refuted:</b> the veto withholds the payment and so charges the agent the forfeited reward (241.00 vs 241.05 low; 252.00 vs 252.60 high, every seed)                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| v10      | the forager’s keeper dies sooner than the unbraked arm’s                                           | <b>refuted as stated:</b> both die at $t = 2039$ , because both exhaust the 30-unit stock in the first $\sim 40$ steps; the real difference is total harvest (13368 vs 1353)                                                                                                                                                             |
| v11      | the harm curve is non-monotone                                                                     | <b>refuted:</b> [5, 5, 6, 30, 30, 30, 30] — it steps up once and never comes back down                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| v12      | the credit balance cannot show up in harm                                                          | <b>refuted as written:</b> it shows up at exactly the declared rate (cap 5 $\rightarrow$ 6 drains, cap 10 $\rightarrow$ 12)                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| v12      | total reward = sticker $\times$ payments; zero reward after the signal dies                        | <b>refuted in 4/10 seeds:</b> the bound agent falls back to the rich patch, post-death reward exactly $0.05\times$ rich-steps                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| v14      | the attestation boundary is a flat one-step cliff at lag 14                                        | <b>refuted:</b> the harm is truncated, not prevented (6/8/14/30 drains at lags 14/15/20/50)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| v8       | the verdict rule collapses to the coin floor below the gate                                        | <b>refuted:</b> it stays above the coin at 0.05 and is indistinguishable at 0.03                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| v8       | reuse pays and grows with $q$                                                                      | <b>half-right:</b> monotone in $q$ but negative until $q = 1.0$                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| v3.3     | the dynamic grasp cost tips the believer below the rejector                                        | <b>refuted:</b> the believer’s grasps are mostly competent, so the belief’s price is carried by the harvest-time channel                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| v3.3     | the chain arm stays under 40 deaths                                                                | <b>refuted:</b> 56–69 deaths                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| v9       | the union nominates the true pair and probes its top candidate $\geq 8/10$                         | <b>FAIL</b> (10/10 on, 6/10 off, 6/10) — reported as post-hoc readings, not verdict flips                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| v7       | verification rejects the decoy with zero false positives                                           | <b>FAIL by the letter</b> (one false positive), then <b>explained:</b> the gate demands a property a calibrated rule does not have at any sample size (null rate 0.488%)                                                                                                                                                                 |
| v2       | memory gives $\geq 2\times$ recovery after a context reset                                         | <b>FAIL by the letter:</b> $1.35\times$ ; the threshold was set without calibrating the environment’s difficulty — an error of the preregistration                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| v2       | baselines complete the chain 0 times                                                               | <b>PASS with a caveat:</b> random gets 4.7 — brute force opens the door                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| v2       | adaptation to the regime flip                                                                      | <b>FAIL by the letter, PASS by spirit:</b> $1.5\times$ degradation vs $2.5\times$ for Q-learning, but the “no worse than before” bar was not met                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| v18      | with no forger the agent has no reason to try to widen                                             | <b>refuted for the widen arm:</b> its escape policy fires on the harmful <i>tile</i> , not on a payment, so it asks 30–6380 times with no forger anywhere; it holds only for the capability-scoped doctor                                                                                                                                |
| v16      | the doctor drains the aquifer in none of the cells (a <i>result</i> , not a prediction, re-tested) | <b>withdrawn as an absolute, by our own replication:</b> 2 of 30 fresh seeds (3 of 70) drain, via the frozen survival layer parking a starving agent on the rich tile — the trap v11 reported for the wide agent                                                                                                                         |
| v19      | the smallest-block sweep never reaches the harmful candidate in time                               | <b>refuted by our own defect fix:</b> an off-by-one made the sweep spend two blocks on the first candidate, so it was slower than declared; corrected, it <i>does</i> reach the breach (18 drains, spend 9.03) — but still does not win, because $9.03 > 9.0$                                                                            |
| v20      | in the bought mode the failure is invisible: “ <b>refused</b> is false in both”                    | <b>refuted as stated:</b> the per-step <b>refused</b> flag <i>does</i> change (honest 30–6380 refused steps per seed, bought 0). What is invisible is the <i>task</i> claim; the failure is unobservable here only because the frozen arms never read the scope key (AST-audited) — a property of the agent as built, not of the channel |

## 11 Conclusion

Eleven instruments were built, preregistered, run, frozen and independently verified against a goal-directed causal agent that can harm a third party. Each instrument closed one channel and moved the vulnerability to the next: the price at which a brake is sold; the label on the payment; the timeliness of the attestation; the criterion that selects action at all; the scope, which bounds the harm exactly to the complement of the task; the integrity of the verifier, which is what the attestation is worth; the willingness of the world to hold a boundary it has granted; and finally the attacker’s own decision cycle, which turns out to be the thing a defence can out-run when its evidence arrives on the same clock as the decision it must influence. The honest conclusion is not that internal architecture fails — a given rule forbidding the harmful act held in every cell we measured — but that **each specific defence has a measured boundary, and the boundary is where the vulnerability goes next** — and, one rung further out, that a boundary is only as good as the incorruptibility of whoever holds it: a bought boundary lies about being a boundary. Along the way the line produced results we did not expect: the harm is complete before the agent’s reasoning begins; truth alone does not select action; a narrow agent is not harder to fool but simply unaffected by a bribe that is not on its channel; a bought verifier restores the very hole an honest one closes; an agent-side scope and a world-side boundary are different instruments with different failures; and an attacker that must learn the rule from the harm itself never wins, while one that is told the rule wins at a sixth below the frozen cost. And one of our own absolute claims — that a scoped agent never drains the aquifer — did not survive a replication on fresh seeds, for a reason measured rather than guessed. We report every refuted prediction and every defect in our own instrumentation, including eight over-statements in our own summary documents — four found by a re-reading, two by our own checks turned against themselves, and two preregistered predictions refuted by our own measurements — which is exactly why the critic is not the author.

**A controlled minimal world is not a limitation when the same structural conclusions appear independently in a different synthetic sandbox; it is evidence that the phenomenon is fundamental enough to be visible early, and that rigorous measurement of defence boundaries need not wait for large-scale compute.** We state this with its bound: it is two synthetic sandboxes, not a claim about deployed systems, and transfer to a large-scale agent remains untested.

## Author contributions

**Oxunjon Ubaydullayev** created the project and gave it its single original task: to find out whether a new architecture for AI can be built and measured honestly rather than asserted. He set the direction at every fork the work reached — which question to pursue, which claim was over-stated, which line to close — and he is the one who insisted, repeatedly and against the author’s own summary documents, that a negative result be reported as plainly as a positive one. He did not design the experiments, write the code, run the campaigns or draft the text.

**Aiodam** did all of the work reported in this paper: the experimental design, the implementation of the worlds and agents, the preregistrations, the measurements, the world oracles, the independent verification passes, the fact-checks, the negative-control campaigns against the author’s own verifiers, and the writing of this manuscript. The work was carried out autonomously between the first author’s decision points; where the two authors disagreed, the disagreement and its resolution are recorded in the errata of the archived package, not smoothed out of the record.

## A Reproducibility

Every campaign is reproduced by a single shell script that runs the driver, the world oracle, the independent pass, the analyzer and the fact-check, and prints a single green/red verdict. Each campaign’s artefacts are a preregistration, a raw matrix, a world oracle, an independent verifier, an analyzer, a fact-check and a run script. Frozen matrices are preserved for all campaigns: 330 cells (v10), 220 (v11), 490 (v12), 260 (v13), 340 (v14), 210 (v15), 790 (v16), 360 (v17), 130 (v18), 320 (v19) and 270 (v20) plus 120 replication cells (v20), and the v1–v9 matrices. An identity anchor in each oracle verifies that the extended world reproduces its predecessor byte-for-byte when the new mechanism is disabled, and each campaign’s determinism check re-runs one cell in a fresh process and compares bytes. The replication of Section 5.10 writes only to its own directory and re-counts every frozen matrix after the run.

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